JUDGES

Conversational Version

Partial Conquest of Remaining Territory

1:1 After Joshua died, the people asked the LORD, *"Who will go up first to fight the Canaanites?"*

2He said, *"Judah. I'll deliver the land to him."*

3Judah said to his brother Simeon, *"Go with me to my territory to fight the Canaanites, and I'll go with you to yours."*

So he went with him.

4Judah went up and the LORD delivered 10,000 Canaanites and Perizzites to him at Bezek. **5-6**They attacked Adoni-bezek **6**and he fled, but they caught him and cut off his thumbs and big toes. **7**He said, *"Seventy kings with their thumbs and big toes cut off used to pick up scraps under my table. God has done to me what I've done."* They took him to Jerusalem, where he died.

8Judah fought Jerusalem and took it. They struck it with the sword and set it on fire. **9**Then they went down to fight the Canaanites in the hill country, the Negev, and the western foothills. **10**Judah attacked the Canaanites in Hebron (called Kiriath-arba before) and defeated Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai. **Jud 1:1-10**

11From there they attacked Debir (called Kiriath-sepher before). **12**Caleb said, *"Whoever takes Keriath-sepher, I'll give my daughter Achsah as a wife."* **13**Othniel son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother, took it, and *Caleb* gave her to him. **14**When she came to him, she urged him to ask her father for a field. She got down from her donkey, and Caleb asked, *"What do you want for yourself?"*

15*"A present. Since you've put me in the Negev, give me springs."*

Caleb gave her the upper and lower springs.

16The descendants of Moses' father-in-law, the Kenite, moved from the City of Palms to the Wilderness of Judah in the Negev near Arad, and settled with the people. **17**Judah went with Simeon and defeated the Canaanites in Zephath and "destroyed" it; so the city was called Hormah. **18**Judah also took Gaza, Ashkelon, and Ekron, and their territories. **19**The LORD was with Judah, and he gained possession of the hill country, but he couldn't drive out the people in the plain; they had iron chariots. **20**They gave Hebron to Caleb, like Moses had said. He drove out Anak's three sons. **Jud 1:11-20**

21But Benjamin didn't drive out the Jebusites in Jerusalem; they still live there among them.

22Joseph went up against Bethel and the LORD was with them. **23**Joseph's house spied out Bethel (called Luz before). **24**The spies saw a man coming out of the city, and said, *"Show us how*

to get into the city, and we'll have mercy on you." [25]He showed them. They struck it with the sword, but they let him and his family go. [26]He went to the Hittites and built a city he called Luz. That's still its name.

[27]Manasseh didn't drive out the people in Beth-shean, Taanach, Dor, Ibleam, or Megiddo and their villages. The Canaanites kept living there. [28]When Israel grew stronger, they put them to forced labor; but they didn't completely drive them out. **Jud 1:21-28**

[29]Ephraim didn't drive out the Canaanites in Gezer, who kept living among them.

[30]Zebulun didn't drive out the people in Kitron or Nahalol, who kept living among them, subject to forced labor.

[31]Asher didn't drive out the people in Acco, Sidon, Ahlab, Achzib, Helbah, Aphik, or Rehob. [32]They lived among the Canaanites.

[33]Naphtali didn't drive out the people in Beth-shemesh or Beth-anath. They lived among those Canaanites, who became forced labor.

[34]The Amorites pressed the Danites back into the hill country. They wouldn't let them come down to the plain. [35]They went on living in Mount Heres. Aijalon, and Shaalbim. But Joseph's house pressed heavily on them and subjected them to forced labor. [36]The border of the Amorites ran from the ascent of Akrabbim, from Sela and up. **Jud 1:29-36**

The Angel of the Lord Comes to Bokim

2:[1]The angel of the LORD went up from Gilgal to Bochim and said,

> *"I brought you up from Egypt to this land that I swore to give your ancestors. I said, 'I'll never break my covenant with you.* [2]*Don't make any covenant with the people here. Tear down their altars.' But you haven't obeyed me.* [3]*So I won't drive them out. They'll become adversaries, and their gods will be a snare to you."*

[4]When the angel of the LORD told the people that, they "cried" out loud. [5]They called the place Bochim and sacrificed to the LORD there.

The Death of Joshua

[6]When Joshua dismissed the people to their inheritances, [7]they served the LORD while he was alive and the elders that outlived him, who'd seen the LORD's great work for Israel. [8]He died at 110. [9]They buried him in his inheritance in Timnath-heres in the hill country of Ephraim north of Mount Gaash. [10]That whole generation passed on to their ancestors, and another generation grew up that hadn't known the LORD or seen his work for Israel. **Jud 2:1-10**

Disobedience and Defeat

[11]The people did sin and served the images of Baal [13]and Ashtoreth [12]and forsook their ancestors' God. They worshiped the gods of people around them. That made the LORD angry; [14]so he let plunderers sell them to their enemies so they couldn't stand against them any longer. [15]Whenever they marched out, he opposed them like he'd sworn. They were in dire straits.

[16]Then the LORD raised up judges to save them from their plunderers, [17]but they wouldn't listen to them. They carried on prostitution with other gods and soon turned aside from the way their ancestors lived. [18]Whenever the LORD raised up a judge for them, he was with him and saved them as long as the judge was alive. He took pity on their groaning. [19]But whenever the judge died, they'd turn back and do worse than their ancestors and wouldn't quit. [20]The LORD was angry and said,

> *"They've sinned against my covenant like their ancestors.* [21]*From now on, I won't drive out any nation Joshua left when he died.* [22]*I'll use them to test Israel to see if they'll follow me like their ancestors."* [[23]] **Jud 2:11-23**

3:[1]The LORD left those nations to test the Israelites that hadn't experienced war in Canaan. [[2]] [3]The nations were

the five lords of the Philistines,
all the Canaanites,
Sidonians,
the Hivites on Mount Lebanon from Mount Baal-hermon to Lebo-hamath.

[4]They served to test whether Israel would obey the LORD's commandments to their ancestors by Moses. [5]So the Israelites lived among the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites. [6]They intermarried with them and served their gods.

Othniel Judges Israel

[7]Israel forgot the LORD its God and served the images of Baal and Ashtoreth. [8]He was angry and sold Israel to Cushan-rishathaim, king of Mesopotamia, for **8 years**. [9]When they appealed to the LORD, he raised up **Othniel** son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother, to deliver them. [10]The Spirit of the LORD stirred him up to judge Israel. He went out to war, and the LORD delivered Cushan-rishathaim to him. [11]The land had peace for **40 years**. Then Othniel died. **Jud 3:1-11**

Ehud Judges Israel

[12]The people sinned again, and the LORD strengthened Eglon, king of Moab. [13]He gathered the Amorites and Amalekites, defeated Israel, and took the City of Palms. [14]Israel served him for **18 years**.

[15]But when Israel appealed to the LORD, he raised up **Ehud** son of Gera, a Benjamite, a left-handed man. Israel sent tribute by him to Eglon. [16]Ehud made a double-edged sword 18ins

long and fastened it under his right thigh under his clothes. [17]He presented the tribute to Eglon, an obese man. [18]When he sent away the people that carried it. [19]At the idols near Gilgal, he turned back and said, *"I have a private message for you, King."* He said, *"Just a minute."* His attendants went out. [20]Ehud came to him while he was sitting alone in his cool roof room. He said, *"I have a message from God for you."* He got up from his seat. [21]Ehud reached with his left hand, took his sword from his right thigh, and thrust it into *Eglon's* belly. [22]The hilt went in after the blade, and the fat closed over the blade. He didn't pull it out, and the refuse came out. [23]Ehud went out to the anteroom, closed the doors to the roof room, and locked them. **Jud 3:12-23**

[24]When he'd gone, the servants came and saw the doors locked, and thought he was relieving himself in the cool room. [25]They waited till they were completely confused. When he still didn't come out, they took the key and opened the doors. There he was on the floor, dead.

[26]While they delayed, Ehud escaped past the idols to Seirah. [27]When he arrived, he blew the ram's horn in the hill country of Ephraim. The people went down from the hill country with him leading. [28]He told them, *"Follow me. The LORD will deliver the Moabites to you."* They went down and seized the fords of the Jordan from the Moabites and wouldn't let anybody cross. [29]They killed about 10,000 Moabites, strong, able-bodied men. No one escaped. [30]Israel subdued Moab that day. The land had peace for **80 years**.

Shamgar Judges Israel

[31]After him came **Shamgar** son of Anath, who killed 600 Philistines with an ox goad and delivered Israel. **Jud 3:24-31**

Deborah Judges Israel

4:[1]After Ehud died, the people sinned again, [2]and the LORD sold them to Jabin, king of Canaan in Hazor. Sisera commanded his army from Harosheth-hagoyim. [3]The people appealed to the LORD because *Sisera* had 900 iron chariots and oppressed Israel cruelly for **20 years**.

[4]**Deborah**, a prophetess, wife of Lappidoth, was judging Israel. [5]She sat under the Palm of Deborah between Ramah and Bethel in the hill country of Ephraim. The people came up to her for judgment. [6]She sent for **Barak** son of Abinoam from Kedesh in Naphtali,

> *"The LORD God of Israel commands you, 'Gather to Mount Tabor 10,000 troops from Naphtali and Zebulun. [7]I'll draw out Sisera, Jabin's general, to meet you by the Kishon River with his chariots and troops. I'll give him to you.'"*

[8]Barak said, *"If you'll go, I'll go. If you won't, I won't."*

[9]*"I'll go with you, but that won't give* you any *honor. The LORD will be selling Sisera to a woman."*

She went with him to Kedesh, [10]and Barak called Zebulun and Naphtali to Kedesh; 10,000 men went up with him. **Jud 4:1-10**

11Heber the Kenite had moved away from the Kenites, descendants of Hobab, Moses' *brother*-in-law*. He had pitched his tent as far away as the oak in Zaanannim near Kedesh.

12When Sisera heard that Barak had gone up to Mount Tabor, **13**he called out his 900 iron chariots and all his army from Harosheth-hagoyim to the Kishon River. **14**Deborah told Barak, *"Get up! The LORD is going to deliver Sisera to you today. Isn't it the LORD that's leading you out?"* So Barak went down from Mount Tabor with 10,000 men. **15**The LORD routed Sisera, his chariots, and army. Sisera jumped down from his chariot and fled on foot. **16**Barak chased the chariots and the army *back home* to Harosheth-hagoyim, and Sisera's whole army fell by the sword.

17Sisera fled to the tent of Jael, wife of Heber the Kenite, because he and Heber's family had been on good terms. **18**Jael came out to meet him, *"Turn aside, Sir. You don't have to be afraid."* He turned aside into her tent, and she covered him with a rug. **19**He said, *"Please give me a little water. I'm thirsty."* She opened a skin of milk and gave him a drink and covered him up. **20**He said, *"Stand at the door. If anybody comes and asks if anybody's here, say, 'No.'"* **21**But she took a tent peg and a hammer, and went quietly to him and drove the peg into his temple till it stuck into the ground while he was asleep, exhausted. That's how he died. **22**As Barak pursued him, Jael went out to meet him, *"Come here, I'll show you the man you're looking for."* He went into her tent and found Sisera lying there dead with the tent peg through his temple.

23God subdued Jabin that day in front of Israel. **24**They kept pressing harder and harder on him till they'd destroyed him. **Jud 4:11-24**

The Song of Deborah

5:1 Deborah and Barak sang that day,

2*"Bless the LORD!*
because the leaders led in Israel,
the people volunteered.
3*Hear, you kings; listen, you officials;*
I'll sing to the LORD;
I'll praise Israel's God.
4*LORD, when you went out from Seir,*
when you marched from Edom,
the ground shook,
the sky dripped,
yes, the clouds dripped water.
5*The mountains shook in front of the LORD;*
you, Sinai, shook in front of Israel's God. **Jud 5:1-5**

6*"In the days of Shamgar son of Anath,*

in the days of Jael, caravans ceased;
travelers kept to the back roads.
7 *The rural people ceased in Israel;*
they ceased till you arose, Deborah,
as a mother in Israel.
8 *When the people chose new gods,*
war was in the gates;
not a shield or spear was seen
among 40,000 in Israel.
9 *My heart goes out to Israel's commanders,*
who volunteered willingly among the people.
Bless the LORD. **Jud 5:6-9**

10 *"Sing, you that ride white donkeys,*
who sit on rich carpets
and travel on the highway.
11 *At the sound of those who separate flocks*
by the watering places,
they repeat the LORD's triumphs,
the triumphs of his rural people in Israel.
Then the LORD's people went down to the gates. **Jud 5:10-11**

12 *"Wake up, wake up, Deborah!*
Wake up, wake up, and sing!
Arise, Barak;
lead away your captives, son of Abinoam.
13 *The remnant of the nobles came down;*
the LORD's people came down
for him against the powerful.
14 *They set out to the valley from Ephraim;*
they followed you, Benjamin, with your kin.
The commanders marched down from Machir;
from Zebulun they marched
who carry the marshal's staff. **Jud 5:12-14**
15 *The officials of Issachar came with Deborah;*
as Issachar came *so did Barak.*
They rushed out to the valley at his heels,
but the clans of Reuben held back.
16 *Why did you linger among the sheepfolds?*

To hear the piping for the flocks?
The clans of Reuben held back.
17 *Gilead stayed put beyond the Jordan.*
Why did Dan stay with his *ships?*
Asher sat still at the coast by the sea
and settled down by his landings.
18 *Zebulun was a people that risked their lives,*
Naphtali, too, on the high places in the countryside.
Jud 5:15-18

19 *"The kings came and fought;*
they fought the kings of Canaan
at Taanach by the water of Megiddo;
they got no spoils of silver.
20 *The stars fought from the sky;*
from their courses they fought Sisera.
21 *The current of the Kishon swept them away,*
the rushing torrent in the Kishon.
March on, my soul, with confidence!

22 *"Then the horses' hoofs beat loud*
with the galloping of steeds. **Jud 5:19-22**

23 *"'Curse Meroz,' the angel of the* LORD *says;*
'put its people under a severe curse.
They didn't come to help the LORD
against the powerful.'
24 *May Jael be most fortunate among women,*
the wife of Heber the Kenite,
most fortunate among women in the tent.
25 *He asked for water; she gave him milk.*
She brought him curds in a beautiful bowl.
26 *She took a tent peg*
and a workman's hammer;
she struck Sisera a blow
and crushed his head.
She shattered and pierced his temple.
27 *He sank, he fell;*
he lay still at her feet.
He sank and fell down dead at her feet. **Jud 5:23-27**

28 *"She looked out the window;*
Sisera's mother gazed through the lattice.
'Why is his chariot so long in coming?
Why do the hoof beats with his chariots tarry?'
29 *Her wise ladies answer;*
no, she answers herself,
30 *'Aren't they finding and dividing the spoil—*
a young woman or two for every man.
spoil of embroidered dyed work for Sisera,
two pieces of dyed work for the spoiler's neck?'

31 *"May all your enemies perish that way, LORD!*
But may your friends be like the sun
when it rises at it brightest."

The land had peace for 40 years. **Jud 5:28-31**

Gideon Judges Israel

6:1 Israel did what the LORD considered sin; so he gave them over to Midian for 7 years. **2** Because of Midian, the Israelites made dens and caves and barricades in the mountains. **3** Whenever they sowed anything, the Midianites, Amalekites, and people from the east would come up and attack them. **4** They'd camp against them and destroy their crops as far as the territory around Gaza. They wouldn't leave any sustenance in Israel—sheep, oxen, or donkeys. **5** They'd come up with their livestock, camels, and tents like locusts in number. They trashed the land **6** and brought Israel low. The people appealed to the LORD, **Jud 6:1-6**

[7] **8** and he sent a prophet,

"The LORD God of Israel says, 'I led you out of slavery in Egypt **9** *and delivered you from other oppressors. I drove them out and gave you their land.* **10** *I told you, "I'm the LORD your God. Don't be afraid of the Amorites' gods where you're living." But you've ignored me.'"*

11 Now the angel of the LORD came and sat under the terebinth tree at Ophrah, which belonged to Joash the Abiezrite. His son **Gideon** was beating out wheat in a winepress to hide it from the Midianites.

12 The angel appeared to him, *"The LORD is with you, brave soldier!"* **Jud 6:7-12**

13 Gideon said,

"Sir, if he's with us, why is this happening? Where are his wonderful deeds our ancestors talked about when he brought us up from Egypt? He's thrown us away now and delivered us to Midian."

14 *"Take your strength and deliver Israel from them. Haven't I sent you?"*

15 *"LORD, how can I deliver Israel? My clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I'm the least in my family."*

16 *"I'll be with you. You'll strike the Midianites as if they were one man."*

17 *"If I'm pleasing to you, give me a sign that it's you speaking to me.* **18** *Don't leave till I come back with your present."*

"I'll wait." **Jud 6:13-18**

19 Gideon went into the house and fixed a kid and cakes without yeast from 1.1 bushels 1 ephah of flour. He put the meat in a basket and the broth in a pot, and took them to him under the terebinth tree. **20** God's angel said, *"Put the meat and cakes on this rock and pour the broth over them."* When he did that, **21** the angel touched the meat and cakes with the tip of his staff. Fire flared up from the rock and consumed them, and he vanished. **22** Then Gideon surmised that he was the angel of the LORD, *"Lord GOD! I've seen the angel of the LORD directly."* **23** But the LORD said, *You don't have to be afraid. You won't die."* **24** Then Gideon built an altar to him and called it The LORD Is Peace [*Yahveh Shalom*]. It's still standing at Ophrah, which belongs to the Abiezrites.

25 That night the LORD told him,

"Take your father's bull and a second bull seven years old, and pull down your father's altar to Baal. Cut down the Asherah pole beside it. **26** *Build an altar to the LORD your God on top of the fortress here, with stones laid in order. Offer the second bull as a burnt offering with the wood from the Asherah pole you cut down."*

27 Gideon took ten servants and did that. He was too afraid of family and townspeople to do it in the daytime, so he did it at night. **Jud 6:19-27**

28 When people in town got up early, Baal's altar was pulled down, the Asherah pole was cut down, and the second bull was offered on the altar *Gideon* built. **29** They asked one another who did it. After they asked around, *people* said, *"Gideon son of Joash."* **30** They told Joash, *"Bring your son out to die. He pulled down Baal's altar and cut down the Asherah pole."* **31** Joash said to everybody lined up against him,

"Will you defend Baal or his cause? Whoever fights for him will be put to death by morning. If he's a god, he can defend himself. It's his altar that Gideon *tore down!"* **Jud 6:28-31**

32 That day he called him Jerubbaal ("Let Baal Fight Him") because he tore down his altar.

33 Then the Midianites, Amalekites, and people east *of the Jordan* joined forces, crossed the Jordan, and camped in the Valley of Jezreel. **34** The Spirit of the LORD stirred up Gideon. He

blew the ram's horn and called the Abiezrites to follow him. [35]He sent messengers all over Manasseh, Asher, Zebulun, and Naphtali to follow him too. They went up to meet them.

[36]Then Gideon said to God,

> *"If you're going to deliver Israel by me,* [37]*I'm laying a wool fleece on the threshing floor. If there's dew on it but the ground around it's dry, I'll know you'll deliver Israel by me."*

[38]That's what happened. When he got up early, he wrung out enough dew to fill a bowl. [39]Then he said to God,

> *"Don't be angry with me. Let me test* you *one* more *time with the fleece. Let it be dry and the ground around it have dew on it."*

[40]That's what God did that night. It was dry just on the fleece; the ground was wet. **Jud 6:32-40**

7:1 Then Jerubbaal (Gideon) and the people got up early and camped beside the Spring of Harod. Midian's camp was in the valley north of them by the Hill of Moreh.

[2]The LORD told Gideon,

> *"You have too many for me to deliver the Midianites to you. I don't want Israel to pride themselves in thinking they've delivered themselves.* [3]*Tell whoever is afraid and trembling to go home."*
>
> Gideon tested them; 22,000 went back, 10,000 stayed.

[4]The LORD told Gideon,

> *"There are still too many. Take them down to the creek; I'll test them. The ones I tell you, will go with you. The others won't."*

[5]He took them down to the water. The LORD told Gideon,

> *"The ones that lap water like a dog, put in a group. Those who kneel down to drink put in another group."*

[6]300 put their hands to their mouths. The rest got on their knees to drink from the water. [7]The LORD told Gideon, *"I'll deliver the Midianites to you with 300 men. Send the rest home."* [8]He took the people's jars and rams' horns and sent the rest home. Midian camped below them in the valley. **Jud 7:1-8**

[9]That night the LORD told him,

> *"Get up and go down against the camp. I'll deliver it to you.* [10]*If you're afraid, go down with your servant Purah.* [11]*You'll hear what they're saying and be confident about attacking the camp."*

He went down with Purah to the outposts of the camp. [12]The Midianites, Amalekites, and people from east *of the Jordan* lay along the valley like locusts. Their camels were without number, like sand on the shore. [13]When Gideon got there, a man was telling his friend about a dream,

"I dreamed that a loaf of barley bread tumbled into the camp. It knocked a tent over and flattened it."

14His friend answered, *"That's the sword of Gideon, a man of Israel. God is going to deliver Midian and the* erst of the *army to him."* **Jud 7:9-14**

15When Gideon heard the dream and its interpretation, he bowed *in worship* and went back to camp. He said, *"Get up! The LORD is going to deliver Midian's army to you."* **16**He divided the 300 men into three companies. He gave them all rams' horns and empty jars with torches inside. **17**He told them,

> *"Do what I do when I get to the edge of the camp.* **18***When I and the ones with me blow the rams' horns, then blow* your *rams' horns all around the camp, and raise the battle cry, 'For the LORD and Gideon!'"*

19Gideon and the 300 got to the edge of the camp when they'd just set the middle watch. **20**They blew the rams' horns and broke the jars, holding the torches in their left hands and the rams' horns in their right, and raised the battle cry, *"A sword for the LORD and Gideon!"* **21**Every man stood in place all around the camp, and *Midian's* whole army screamed and fled. **22**When the *Israelites* blew the 300 rams' horns, the LORD set every man's sword against his fellow soldier throughout *Midian's* army. The army fled all the way to Beth-shittah toward Zererah, as far as the border of Abel-meholah by Tabbath. **23***Gideon* called out Naphtali, Asher, and Manasseh to chase them. **24**He sent messengers all over the hill country of Ephraim, *"Come down against the Midianites and seize* control of *the water, as far as Beth-barah and the Jordan."* Ephraim came out and seized it. **25**They captured Oreb and Zeeb, Midian's two rulers. In the chase they killed Oreb at the Rock of Oreb and Zeeb at the Winepress of Zeeb. They brought their heads to Gideon beyond the Jordan. **Jud 7:15-25**

8:1 The men in Ephraim said to him,

> *"What have you done to us, not calling us when you went to fight Midian?"* They were in animated contention with him.

2He said,

> *"What have I done compared to you? Isn't the gleaning of grapes in Ephraim better than the vintage in Abiezer?* **3***God delivered Oreb and Zeeb to you. What have I done compared to that?"*

They calmed down.

4Gideon and the 300 crossed the Jordan, exhausted from chasing. **5**He said to the men in Succoth, *"Give loaves of bread to the ones with me. I'm afraid they're worn out, and I'm chasing Zebah and Zalmunna, kings of Midian."*

6The officials in Succoth said, *"Are Zebah and Zalmunna already in hand that we should feed your army?"*

7Gideon said, *"All right, then. When the LORD delivers them to me, I'll flail you with wild briers and thorns."* **8**He went on up to Penuel and asked them the same thing, and they answered the same way.

[9]He told them, *"When I come back after peace is restored, I'll tear down this tower."*

Jud 8:1-9

[10]Zebah and Zalmunna were in Karkor with about 15,000 men, what were left from the entire army from east *of the Jordan*; 120,000 swordsmen had fallen. [11]Gideon went up the caravan route east of Nobah and Jogbehah and caught them in a surprise attack. [12]Zebah and Zalmunna fled. *Gideon* chased them and captured them and sent the whole army into a panic.

[13]When he went back from the battle by the ascent of Heres, [14]he captured a young man from Succoth and questioned him. He wrote down the *names of the* 77 officials and elders in Succoth. [15]*Gideon* came and said, *"Look, Zebah and Zalmunna that you taunted me about, 'Are Zebah and Zalmunna already in hand that we should feed your exhausted men?'* [16]He disciplined the city elders with thorns and briers from the countryside. [17]He tore down the tower at Penuel and killed the men in the city.

[18]He asked Zebah and Zalmunna, *"What kind of men did you kill at Tabor?"*

They answered, *"Every one of them was like you, like a king's son."*

[19]*He* said, *"They were my brothers, my mother's sons. As sure as the LORD lives, if you had let them live, I wouldn't have killed you."*

[20]He told Jether his firstborn to *get up and kill them.*

But the young man was afraid to draw his sword because he was young.

[21]Then Zebah and Zalmunna said, *"Be a man. Come do it yourself."*

Gideon got up and killed them and took the crescents off their camels' necks. **Jud 8:10-21**

[22]Then the Israelites said to him, *"Be our ruler, you, your son, and your grandson as well. You've delivered us from Midian."*

[23]*"I won't be your ruler. My son won't either. The LORD will be your ruler.* [24]*Let me ask you for one thing, though. Each of you give me the earrings from your spoil."*

[25]*"We'll be glad to."* They spread out a cloak and every man tossed on it the earrings from his spoil. [26]The gold earrings weighed 50 pounds [1700 shekels] of gold plus the camels' crescents. [27]Gideon made an ephod out of it and put it in Ophrah, his hometown. Israel prostituted themselves with it there, and it became a snare to Gideon and his family. [28]So Israel subdued Midian; they didn't threaten anymore. The land had peace for **40 years** during Gideon's life.

[29]Jerubbaal/*Gideon* went and lived in his own house. [30]He had 77 sons from many wives. [31]A concubine of his in Shechem also had a son he named Abimelech. [32]Gideon died at a good old age, and they buried him in the tomb of his father Joash at Ophrah among the Abiezrites.

[33]As soon as he died, the people went back to worshiping the images of Baal. They made Baal-berith their god. [34]They didn't remember the LORD their God, who had rescued them from their enemies in every direction, [35]or show kindness to Jerubbaal's family in return for everything he'd done for Israel. **Jud 8:22-35**

Abimelech's Conspiracy

9:**1**Abimelech went to his mother's relatives in Shechem and said to her clan, **2***"Ask the leaders in Shechem which is better: for Jerubbaal's 70 sons to rule you or for one* man *to rule you. Remember, I'm your flesh and bone."* **3**His mother's relatives circulated that around for him, and the people were inclined to follow him *because* he was their *kin.* **4**They gave him 70 pieces of silver from Baal-berith's temple. He used them to hire worthless, reckless fellows **5**to go with him to his father's family at Ophrah and kill his 70 brothers on one stone. But Jotham, Jerubbaal's youngest son, hid. **6**The people in Shechem and Beth-millo gathered and made Abimelech king by the Oak of the Pillar at Shechem. **Jud 9:1-6**

7When Jotham heard about it, he went and stood on top of Mount Gerizim and shouted,

> *"Listen, people of Shechem, so God will listen to you.* **8***The trees went out to anoint a king. They asked the olive tree to rule them.* **9***But the olive tree said, 'Should I leave my richness that honors gods and mortals, and go sway over the trees?'* **10***The trees said to the fig tree, 'You come and rule us.'* **11***But the fig tree said, 'Should I leave my sweetness and my good fruit, and go sway over the trees?'* **12***The trees said to the grapevine, 'You come and rule us.'* **13***But the grapevine said, 'Should I leave my wine that cheers gods and mortals, and go to sway over the trees?'* **14***Then the trees said to the bramble, 'You come and rule us.'* **15***The bramble said, 'If you're anointing me king in good faith, then come and take refuge in my shade. If not, let fire come out of the bramble and consume the cedars of Lebanon.*
>
> *"[***16***]* **17***My father fought for you and risked his life to rescue you from Midian.* **18***You've risen up against his family and killed his 70 sons on one rock. You've made Abimelech, son of his maidservant, king of Shechem because he's your relative.* **19***If you've acted honorably in good faith with Jerubbaal and his family as his deeds deserved, then be happy with one another.* **20***If not, let fire come out from Abimelech and consume the people in Shechem and Beth-millo."*

21Jotham fled to Beer and lived there for fear of his half-brother. **Jud 9:7-21**

22Abimelech ruled Israel for **3 years**. **23**God put animosity between him and the people in Shechem, and they dealt treacherously with him. **24***That was* so the violence done to Jerubbaal's 70 sons might come on Abimelech who murdered them and on the men who helped him. **25**The men in Shechem put men in ambush against him on the mountaintops and robbed everybody that went by. Abimelech heard about it.

26Gaal son of Ebed moved to Shechem with his relatives and gained the confidence of the people there. **27**They went out and gathered grapes from their vineyards, trod them, and held a feast. They went to the temple of their god and ate and drank, and ranted about Abimelech. **28**Gaal said,

"Who is Abimelech? Why should we serve him? Didn't the son of Jerubbaal and Zebul his officer serve the men of Hamor the father of Shechem? Why then should we serve him? **29***If these people were under my command, I'd remove Abimelech! I'd tell him to muster an army and come out and fight."* **Jud 9:22-29**

30When Zebul the ruler of the city heard what Gaal said, he was mad **31**and sent ambassadors to Abimelech at Arumah,

"Gaal and his relatives have come to Shechem; they're stirring up the city against you. **32***So you and your men go during the night and lie in ambush in the fields.* **33***In the morning at sunup, rush on the city. When he and his men come out against you, do to them what you can."*

34Abimelech and his men got up during the night and laid in ambush against Shechem in four companies. **35**Gaal went out and stood in the entrance of the city gate, and Abimelech and his men rose up from the ambush. **36**When Gaal saw them, he told Zebul, *"Look, men are coming down from the mountains!"*

Zebul said, *"You're just seeing the mountains' shadows."*

37Gaal said again, *"Look, there are men are coming down from the center of the land, and another company is coming from the direction of the Diviners' Oak."*

38Then Zebul said, *"Where's your bragging now, you that said, 'Who is Abimelech that we should serve him?' Aren't these the men you despised? Go fight them."* **39**Gaal led the men out to fight him. **40**Abimelech chased him and he fled. Many fell wounded all the way back to the entrance of the gate. **41**Abimelech retreated to Arumah, and Zebul drove Gaal and his relatives out of Shechem. **Jud 9:30-41**

42The next day the men went out to the fields. Abimelech heard about it. **43**He divided his men into three companies and laid in wait there. When the men come out of the city, he attacked them and killed them. **44**Abimelech and his company rushed up and stood at the entrance to the city gate while the two companies attacked and killed the ones in the fields. **45**Abimelech fought the city all day and took it. He killed the people in it, tore it down, and scattered salt all over it.

46When people in the tower at Shechem heard about it, they withdrew into the fortress of El-berith's temple. **47**When Abimelech found out they were in the tower, **48**he and his men went up to Mount Zalmon. He cut a bundle of brush with an axe and put it on his shoulder. He told his men to hurry and do the same thing. **49**Each one cut a bundle and followed him. He piled the bundles against the fortress and set it on fire over the ones inside. Everybody in the tower died, about 1,000 men and women. **Jud 9:42-49**

50Then Abimelech went to Thebez, camped against it, and took it. **51**But the city had a strong tower. The men and women fled to it, shut themselves in, and went up to the roof. **52**He attacked it and came to burn down the tower door. **53**A woman threw an upper millstone down on him and cracked his skull. **54**Right away he called to his young armor bearer, *"Draw your sword*

and kill me so people won't say a woman killed me." His young man thrust him through, and he died. [55]When Israel saw Abimelech was dead, they went home. [56]So God repaid him for his crime against his father in killing his 70 brothers. [57]God also made the sinfulness of the men in Shechem come back on their heads and made Jotham's curse fall on them. **Jud 9:50-57**

Tola Judges Israel

10:[1]After Abimelech, **Tola** son of Puah son of Dodo from Issachar, rose up to deliver Israel. He lived at Shamir in the hill country of Ephraim [2]and judged Israel **23 years**. He died and was buried at Shamir.

Jair Judges Israel

[3]Then **Jair** from Gilead judged Israel **22 years**. [4]He had 30 sons that rode 30 donkeys and had 30 "towns" people still call Havvoth-jair in Gilead. [5]He died and was buried in Kamon.

Jud 10:1-5

[6]Again, Israel sinned and served the images of Baal and Ashtoreth, and the gods of Aram, Sidon, Moab, the Ammonites and Philistines. They forsook the LORD. [7]His anger flared at them, and he sold them to the Ammonites and Philistines. [8]They crushed and oppressed Israel that year. For **18 years** they oppressed Israel beyond the Jordan in the land of the Amorites (Gilead). [9]The Ammonites crossed the Jordan to fight Judah, Benjamin, and Ephraim; Israel was severely distressed.

[10]Israel cried out to the LORD, *"We've sinned against you; we've left our God and served the images of Baal."*

[11]He said to them,

> *"Didn't I deliver you from the Egyptians, Amorites, Ammonites, and Philistines? [12]The Sidonians, Amalekites, Maonites oppressed you too. You appealed to me and I delivered you from them. [13]Yet you've left me and served other gods; so I won't deliver you anymore. [14]Call out to the gods you've chosen. Have them deliver you."*

[15]They said to the LORD, *"We've sinned. Do whatever you think's good. Just deliver us today, please."* [16]They put away the foreign gods and served the LORD; he couldn't bear Israel's misery any longer. [17]The Ammonites called to arms and encamped in Gilead. Israel came together and camped in Mizpah. [18]The leaders in Gilead said to one another, *"Whoever will lead the fight against the Ammonites will rule everyone in Gilead."* **Jud 10:6-18**

Jephthah Judges Israel

11:[1]**Jephthah** from Gilead was a strong soldier, but he was a prostitute's son. His father was Gilead. [2]Gilead's wife also bore him sons. When her sons grew up, they shoved Jephthah out,

"You won't inherit in our father's family. You're another woman's son." [3]He ran away and lived in the land of Tob. Ruffians gathered around him and went on raids with him.

[4]After a time the Ammonites went to war against Israel. [5]The elders in Gilead went to bring Jephthah from Tob, [6]*"Come, lead us so we can fight the Ammonites."*

[7]*"Didn't you hate me and drive me out of my father's family? Why come to me now when you're in trouble?"*

[8]*"That's why we've turned to you so you can lead us in Gilead to fight the Ammonites."*

[9]*"If you take me home again to fight the Ammonites, and the LORD gives them to me, I'll lead you."*

[10]*"The LORD is witness. We'll do that."*

[11]Jephthah went with them, and the people made him their leader. He swore in at Mizpah in front of the LORD. **Jud 11:1-11**

[12]He sent messengers to the Ammonite king, *"What do you have against me that you've attacked my land?"*

[13]The king answered his messengers, *"Because when Israel came out of Egypt, he took away my land from the Arnon to the Jabbok all along the Jordan. Return it peacefully."*

[14]Jephthah sent messengers back to him,

[15]*"Jephthah says,*

'Israel didn't take away Moab's or Ammon's land. [16]*When the Israelites came up from Egypt, they went through open country to the Red Sea and came to Kadesh.* [17]*Israel sent messengers to the king of Edom to let them pass through your land. But he wouldn't. They sent to the king of Moab too, but he wouldn't consent; so Israel stayed at Kadesh.* [18]*Then they traveled through open country and went around Edom and Moab. They arrived at the east side of Moab and camped on the other side of the Arnon. They didn't go into Moab; the Arnon was its border.* [19]*Israel sent messengers to Sihon, the Amorite king at Heshbon, to let them pass through his land to go to their own country.* [20]*But Sihon wouldn't trust Israel. He gathered his people, camped at Jahaz, and fought them.* [21]*The LORD God of Israel delivered them all to Israel and defeated them. Israel took over Amorite territory* [22]*from the Arnon to the Jabbok, from the desert to the Jordan.* [23]*The LORD expelled the Amorites in front of his own people, and you're going to take it back?* [24]*Wouldn't you keep what your god Chemosh gave you? We'll keep everything the LORD our God has taken for us.* [25]*Are you any better than Balak son of Zippor, king of Moab? Did he ever strive against Israel or go to war with them?* [26]*Why didn't you recover them while Israel lived in Heshbon, Aroer, and their villages, and in the towns on the banks of the Arnon for* ***300 years****?* [27]*I haven't sinned against you.*

You've wronged me by attacking me. May the LORD the Judge decide today between Israel and Ammon."

28But the Ammonite king wouldn't listen. **Jud 11:12-28**

29The Spirit of the LORD stirred up Jephthah, and *he* went through Gilead and Manasseh to Mizpah in Gilead and on to the Ammonites. **30**He vowed to the LORD, *"If you'll give the Ammonites to me,* **31***whatever comes out of my house to meet me when I get back, I'll offer up for a burnt offering."* **32**He crossed over to fight them, and the LORD gave them to him. **33**He massacred them from Aroer to the neighborhood of Minnith, 20 towns, and as far as Abel-keramin. So Israel subdued the Ammonites.

34Jephthah came to his home at Mizpah, and his daughter came out to meet him with tambourines and dancing. She was his only child. **35**When he saw her, he tore his clothes,

"My daughter! You've brought me low! You've brought me great trouble! I've opened my mouth to the LORD, and I can't take back my vow."

36She said, *"Father, if you've vowed to the LORD, do to me what you've vowed, now that he has avenged you of the Ammonites.* **37***Do this for me: let me alone two months so my companions and I can wander in the mountains and mourn my virginity."*

38He said, *"Go ahead."*

He sent her away; she and her companions left to mourn her virginity for two months. **39**She came back to her father, who did with her according to his vow. She never knew a man. It became a custom in Israel **40**that the young women went four days a year to mourn the daughter of Jephthah of Gilead. **Jud 11:29-40**

12:1 The men of Ephraim gathered an army, crossed over *the Jordan* to Zaphon, and said to Jephthah, *"Why did you cross over to fight the Ammonites and not call us to go with you? We'll burn your house on top of you."*

2Jephthah told them, *"My people and I had a major conflict with the Ammonites. When I called you, you didn't deliver me from them.* **3***When I saw that you wouldn't deliver me, I took my life in hand and crossed over against them, and the LORD delivered them to me. Why then have you come up to fight me?"*

4Jephthah gathered the men from Gilead and struck Ephraim because they said, *"You Gileadites are refugees from Ephraim in Ephraim and Manasseh."* **5**The Gileadites captured the Jordan fords. When a refugee from Ephraim asked to go across, the Gileadites would ask him if he was an Ephraimite. If he said, *"No,"* **6**they'd tell him to say *shibboleth.* He'd say *sibboleth* because he couldn't pronounce it right; so they'd kill him. At that time, 42,000 Ephraimites fell.

7Jephthah judged Israel **6 years**. He died and was buried in his city in Gilead. **Jud 12:1-7**

Ibzan Judges Israel

[8]After him **Ibzan** of Bethlehem judged Israel. [9]He had 30 sons and gave 30 daughters in marriage outside his clan. He brought in 30 daughters from outside for his sons. He judged Israel **7 years**. [10]He died and was buried at Bethlehem.

Elon Judges Israel

[11]After him **Elon** from Zebulun judged Israel for **10 years**. [12]He died and was buried at Aijalon in Zebulun.

Abdon Judges Israel

[13]After him **Abdon** son of Hillel from Pirathon judged Israel. [14]He had 40 sons and 30 grandsons that rode on 70 donkeys. He judged Israel **8 years.** [15]He died and was buried at Pirathon in Ephraim in the hill country of the Amalekites. **Jud 12:8-15**

The Samson Cycle

13[1]Israel sinned again, and the LORD gave them to the Philistines for **40 years**.

[2]A man named Manoah in Zorah from the tribe of Dan had a wife that couldn't have children. [3]The angel of the LORD appeared to her,

> *"You haven't been able to have children, but you'll have a son. [4]Make sure not to drink wine or alcohol, or eat anything ceremonially unclean. [5]Your son is not to shave his head. He'll be a Nazirite to me from birth and begin delivering Israel from the Philistines."*

[6]She went and told her husband,

> *"A man of God came to me. He looked like an angel of God, really awesome. I didn't ask him where he was from, and he didn't tell me his name. [7]He said, 'You'll have a son; don't drink wine or alcohol, or eat anything ceremonially unclean, because he'll be a Nazirite to me from birth to death.'"* **Jud 13:1-7**

[8]Manoah pleaded with the LORD, *"Please let the man you sent come again and teach us what to do with the boy."* [9]His angel came again while she was sitting alone in the field. [10]She ran and told Manoah, *"The man that came to me the other day has appeared to me."*

[11]Manoah got up and followed her, *"Are you the man that talked to her?"*

"Yes."

[12]*"When your promise comes true, how should the boy live? What's he supposed to do?"*

[13]*"Make sure to do everything I told her. [14]She's not to eat anything from the grapevine. Don't let her drink wine or alcohol, or eat anything ceremonially unclean."*

[15]*"Let me detain you and fix you a kid."*

[16]*"If you detain me, I won't eat your food. If you prepare a burnt offering, offer it to the* LORD*."* (Manoah didn't know he was the angel of the LORD.)

17 *"What's your name, so when your promise come true, we can honor you?"*

18 *"Why ask what my name is? You can't understand it."*

19 Manoah took the kid with its grain offering and offered it on the rock to the LORD, who worked wonders while Manoah and his wife watched. 20 When the flame went up from the altar, the angel of the LORD went up in it. They fell on their faces on the ground. **Jud 13:8-20**

21 The angel of the LORD never appeared to them again. Then Manoah realized he was the angel of the LORD. 22 He told his wife, *"We going to die! We've seen God."* 23 But she said, *"If he meant to kill us, he wouldn't have accepted our burnt offering and grain offering. He wouldn't have shown us those things or told us such things."* 24 She had a son and named him **Samson**. He grew and the LORD blessed him. 25 The Spirit of the LORD began to stir him in Mahaneh-dan, between Zorah and Eshtaol. **Jud 13:21-25**

Samson's Marriage

14:1 Samson went down to Timnah and saw a young Philistine woman. 2 He came up and told his parents, *"I saw a young Philistine woman at Timnah. Get her for me for a wife."*

3 They said, *"Isn't there a woman among your relatives or all our people that you have to marry a woman from the uncircumcised Philistines?"*

But he told his father, *"Get her for me; I really like her."*

4 His parents didn't know it was all right with the LORD because he was looking for an occasion against the Philistines. At that time the Philistines controlled Israel.

5 Samson went down to Timnah with his parents and came to the vineyards at Timnah. A young lion roared at him, 6 and the Spirit of the LORD came mightily on him. Barehanded he tore the lion apart like it was a kid. 7 He went down and talked to the woman, and she pleased him well. 8 After a while, he went back to take her and turned aside to see the lion's carcass. There was a swarm of bees and honey in it. 9 He scraped it out into his hands and went on, eating as he went. He came to his parents and gave them some to eat; but he didn't tell them he got it out of the lion's carcass. **Jud 14:1-9**

10 His father went down to the woman, and Samson held a feast there. That's the way young men used to do. 11 When the people saw him, they brought 30 companions to be with him. 12 Samson said to them,

> *"Let me put a riddle to you. If you can figure it out and tell me during the week of the feast, I'll give you 30 linen tunics and 30 festive robes.* 13 *If you can't, you'll give me that many."*
>
> *"Let's hear it."*

14 He said, *"Out of the eater came something to eat.*

Out of the strong came something sweet."

In three days they couldn't explain the riddle. **Jud 14:10-14**

15The fourth day, they told Samson's wife, *"Entice your husband to tell us what the riddle means, or we'll burn you and your father's family. Have you invited us here to make us poor?"*

16Samson's wife cried in front of him, *"You just hate me, you don't love me. You've put a riddle to my countrymen and haven't told me what it means."*

He told her, *"I haven't told my own parents. Am I going to tell you?"*

17She cried in his presence the week the feast lasted. The seventh day, he told her, because she pressed him hard. Then she told her countrymen the riddle. **18**The men of the city told him on the seventh day before the sun set,

"What's sweeter than honey?
What's stronger than a lion?"

He told them,

"If you hadn't plowed with my heifer,
you wouldn't have solved my riddle."

19The Spirit of the LORD came on him mightily, and he went down to Ashkelon and killed 30 men from the city. He took their spoil and gave the festive robes to the ones that told him the riddle. In hot anger he went back to his father's house. **20**So Samson's father-in-law gave his wife to his companion, who had been his best man. **Jud 14:15-20**

Samson's Vengeance on the Philistines

15:1 After a while at the time of wheat harvest, Samson went to visit his wife with a kid. He said, *"I'll sleep with my wife in* her *room."*

But her father wouldn't let him go in, **2***"I thought you utterly hated her; so I gave her to your companion. Isn't her younger sister better looking? Take her instead."*

3Samson told them, *"This time I'll be blameless for harming the Philistines."*

4Samson caught 300 foxes, turned them tail to tail, and put a torch between each set of tails. **5**He lit the torches and released the foxes in the Philistines' standing grain and olive orchards. **6**The Philistines asked, *"Who did this?"* They said, *"Samson, the Timnite's son-in-law, because he gave his wife to his companion."* The Philistines came up and burned her and her father. **7**Samson told them, *"If this is what you do, I swear I'll take my revenge on you, and after that I'll quit."* **8**He struck them hip and thigh with a great slaughter and went down to stay in the cave at Etam. **Jud 15:1-8**

9Then the Philistines came up and encamped in Judah and made a raid on Lehi. **10**The men in Judah said, *"Why have you come up against us?"*

They said, *"We've come to tie up Samson and do to him as he did to us."*

11Then 3,000 men from Judah went down to the cave in the rock at Etam, and said to Samson, *"Don't you know the Philistines rule us? What have you done to us?* **12***We've come down to tie you up and give you to the Philistines."*

"Swear that you won't fall on me yourselves."

13 *"We'll tie you up and give you to them. We won't kill you."*
So they tied him up with two new ropes and brought him up from the rock. **Jud 15:9-13**

14When he came to Lehi, the Philistines came shouting to meet him, and the Spirit of the LORD came on him powerfully. The ropes on his arms became like smoldering flax, and his bonds melted off his hands. **15**He found a fresh jawbone from a donkey and killed 1,000 men with it. **16**He said,

"With a donkey's 'jawbone,'
piles on piles,
With a donkey's jawbone,
I killed 1,000 men."

17After he said that, he threw it away. That place was called Ramath-lehi [*Jawbone Hill*].

18He was thirsty and "cried out" to the LORD, *"You've granted me this great deliverance. Am I to die from thirst and fall into the hands of uncircumcised men?"* **19**God split open the hollow place that's in Lehi, and water started coming out of it. When he drank it, his energy returned, and he revived. So he named it En-hakkore; it's still at Lehi. **20**He judged Israel **20 years** during the time of the Philistines. **Jud 15:14-20**

Samson and Delilah

16:1 Samson went to Gaza and saw a prostitute and slept with her. **2**The Gazites heard he was there. They surrounded the place and lay in wait for him all night at the city gate. They kept quiet all night, saying, *"Let's wait till morning light, then kill him."* **3**But Samson lay till midnight, he got up and took hold of the doors of the city gate and its two posts, and pulled them up, bar and all. He put them on his shoulders and carried them to the top of the hill that's near Hebron.
Jud 16:1-3

4Later he fell in love with a woman named Delilah in the Valley of Sorek. **5**The lords of the Philistines came and told her,

"Entice him to see where his great strength lies so we can overpower him, tie him up, and subdue him. We'll each give you 1,100 pieces of silver."

6Delilah said to Samson, *"Please tell me where your great strength lies and how you can be tied up."*

7*"If they tie me up with seven fresh bowstrings that haven't been dried, I'll become as weak as other men."*

8The lords of the Philistines brought her seven fresh bowstrings, and she tied him up with them. **9**She had men lying in wait in an inner room. She said to him, *"The Philistines are coming at you, Samson!"* But he snapped the bowstrings like a piece of string snaps when it touches the fire. So they didn't find out the secret of his strength. **Jud 16:4-9**

10Delilah said to Samson, *"You've made fun of me and lied to me. Please tell me how you can be tied up."*

11 *"If they tie me up with brand new ropes, I'll become as weak as other men."*

12So she tied him up with new ropes and said, *"The Philistines are coming at you, Samson!"* The men lying in wait were in an inner room. But he snapped the ropes off his arms like a thread.

13She said to Samson, *"You've making fun of me and lying to me. Tell me how you can be tied up."*

"If you weave the seven locks of my head with the web and make it tight with the pin, I'll become as weak as any other man."

14So while he was asleep, she wove the seven locks of his hair into the web. She made them tight with the pin, and said, *"The Philistines are coming at you, Samson!"* But he woke up and pulled away the pin, the loom, and the web. **Jud 16:10-14**

15She said to him,

> *"How can you say you love me when you're not honest with me? You've made fun of me three times, and haven't told me where your great strength lies."*

16When she pressed him hard day after day, it distressed him to death. **17**He told her honestly,

> *"A razor has never come on my head. I've been a Nazarite to God from birth. If I'm shaved, my strength will leave; I'll become as weak as any other man."*

18When Delilah saw that he'd been straight with her, she called the lords of the Philistines, *"Come up one more time. He's told me his mind."* They came and brought her the money. **19**She had him sleep on her knees and called a man to shave off the seven locks on his head. **20**She said, *"The Philistines are coming at you, Samson!"* He woke up and said, *"I'll go out as at other times and shake myself free."* He didn't know the LORD had left him. **21**The Philistines grabbed him and gouged out his eyes. They took him down to Gaza and bound him with bronze chains. He ground at the mill in the prison, **22**but his hair began to grow again. **Jud 16:15-22**

The Death of Samson

23The lords of the Philistines gathered to offer a big sacrifice to Dagon their god and to celebrate. *"Our god has delivered our enemy to us."* **24**When the people saw him, they praised their god; *"Our god has delivered our enemy to us, the destroyer of our country who has killed many of us."* **25**When they'd got half drunk, they said, *"Call Samson so he can entertain us."* So they called him out of the prison to entertain them. They made him stand between the pillars. **26**He told the boy that was holding him by the hand, *"Let me feel the pillars the temple rests on so I can lean on them."* **27**The temple was filled with men and women, and the lords of the Philistines were there. There were about 3,000 men and women on the roof, watching while Samson entertained *them*.

28Samson called to the LORD, *"Lord GOD, remember me this one time so I can be avenged on the Philistines for my eyes."* **29**Samson took hold of the two middle pillars the temple rested on, and leaned his weight on them, his right hand on one, his left hand on the other. **30**He said, *"Let me die with the Philistines!"* He bowed with all his might, and the house fell on the lords and people in it. He killed more people in his death than in his life. **31**His brothers and family came down to get him. They took him up and buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol in Manoah's tomb. He'd judged Israel **20 years**. **Jud 16:23-31**

Micah's Idols

17:1A man named Micah in the hill country of Ephraim **2**told his mother, *"I took the 1,100 pieces of silver that were stolen from you, that you told me about and I heard you speak a curse on; I have them."* She said, *"May the LORD bless my son."* **3**He gave them back to her. She said, *"I consecrate the silver to the LORD for my son to make a carved image and a molten image. Now I'll return it to you."* he gave 200 pieces of it to a silversmith to make a carved image and a molten image. It was in Micah's house. **5**He had a shrine and appointed one of his sons as his priest. **6**In those days, there wasn't any king in Israel. Everyone did what seemed right to them. **Jud 17:1-6**

7A young Levite from the family of Judah was living temporarily in Bethlehem in Judah. **8**He left to find a place to live. As he traveled, he came to Micah's house in the hill country of Ephraim. **9**Micah asked him where he was from.

"I'm a Levite from Bethlehem in Judah. I'm going away to find a place to live."

10*"Stay with me. Be a father and a priest for me. I'll give you 10 pieces of silver a year, a suit of clothes, and living expenses."*

11The Levite was content to live with him and became like one of his sons. **12**Micah installed the Levite as his priest in his house. **13**Then he said, *"Now I know the LORD will prosper me; I have a Levite as a priest."* **Jud 17:7-13**

Idolatry Among the Danites

18:1 In those days there wasn't any king in Israel. The tribe of Dan was looking for a territory to live in, because no inheritance in Israel had fallen to them yet. **2**They sent out from Zorah and Eshtaol five capable men from their tribe to spy out the land and explore it. They happened to come to Micah's house and lodged there. **3**While they were at his house, they recognized the voice of the young Levite and turned aside to him, *"Who brought you here? What are you doing here?"*

4*"Micah has done such and such with me and hired me to be his priest."*

5*"Ask God so we can know if our journey will be successful."*

6*"Goodbye. The LORD is watching the journey you're on."* **Jud 18:1-6**

[7]The five men left and came to Laish and saw how the people lived in security, like the Sidonians, quiet and unsuspecting, lacking nothing and possessing wealth. *They saw* how far they were from Sidon and had no dealings with anybody. [8]When they came to their relatives at Zorah and Eshtaol, they asked them for their report. [9]They said,

> *"Let's go up against them. The land is fertile. Aren't you going to do anything? Don't hesitate to take the land.* [10]*When you go, you'll come to an unsuspecting people. The land is extensive. Yes, God will give you the place that doesn't lack anything."*

[11]Then 600 armed men from *the tribe of* Dan set out from Zorah and Eshtaol. [12]They went up and "camped" at Kiriath-jearim in Judah. That's why the place is still called Mahaneh-dan—west of Kiriath-jearim. [13]They went on from there to Micah's house in the hill country of Ephraim.

Jud 18:7-13

[14]The five men that had spied out the country of Laish told their kin, *"Did you know there are household idols, an ephod, a carved image, and a molten image in these houses? Think what you can do."* [15]They turned aside to the house of the young Levite at Micah's home and asked him how he was doing. [16]The 600 armed Danites stood by the gate entrance, [17]and the five men went in and took the carved image, ephod, household idols, and molten image, while the priest stood by the gate entrance with the 600 men. [18]When they went into Micah's house and took those things, the priest asked, *"What are you doing?"*

> [19]They told him, *"Keep your voice down, cover your mouth, and come with us. Be a father and priest for us. Is it better to be a priest for one man's house, or for a family and tribe in Israel?"*

[20]The priest was happy. He took the ephod, household idols, and carved image and went in among the people.

[21]So they turned around and left, putting their little ones, livestock, and goods in front of them. [22]When they were a good way from Micah's house, the men in the houses close by were called out and overtook the Danites. [23]They shouted at them. They turned around and said to Micah, *"What ails you that you've come with such a crowd?"*

[24]He said, *"You take away the gods I made, and the priest, and what do I have left? What do you mean, 'What ails you?'"*

[25]The Danites said, *"Don't raise your voice at us or angry fellows might fall on you. You'll lose your life and your family's lives."*

[26]The Danites left. Micah saw that they were too strong for him and went home. **Jud 18:14-26**

[27]The Danites took what Micah had made and his priest, and went to Laish, to a people quiet and unsuspecting, and struck them with the sword and burned the town. [28]There wasn't any deliverer because it was too far from Sidon, and they didn't have dealings with anybody. It was in the valley that belongs to Beth-rehob. They rebuilt the town and lived in it. [29]They renamed it Dan

after their ancestor, Israel's son. **30**They set up the carved image, and Jonathan son of Gershom son of Moses and his descendants were priests for the tribe of Dan till the time of the captivity. **31**They set up the carved image Micah made for as long as God's house was at Shiloh.

Jud 18:27-31

A Levite and His Concubine

19:1 At that time, there wasn't any king in Israel. A Levite was living in a remote part of the hill country of Ephraim. He took a concubine from Bethlehem, Judah. **2**She got mad at him and went back to her father's family in Bethlehem for four months. **3**Then her husband went after her to speak graciously to her and bring her back. He had a servant and a couple donkeys with him. She[LXX] brought him to her father's family. When her father saw him, he was glad to see him. **4**His father-in-law urged him to stay awhile, so he stayed three days. They ate and drank and lodged there. **5**On the fourth day, they got up early, and he got ready to go, but the girl's father told him, *"Strengthen yourself with some bread and after that you can go."* **6**The two men sat and ate and drank together. The girl's father told him, *"Spend the night and enjoy yourself."* **7**When he got up to go, his father-in-law urged him till he stayed there again. **8**On the fifth day, he got up early to leave, and the girl's father said, *"Strengthen yourself and wait till this afternoon."* So they ate together again. **9**When the man, his concubine, and his servant got up to leave, his father in-law said, *"It's getting toward evening; stay here tonight and relax. You can get up early tomorrow for your trip home."*

Jud 19:1-9

10But he wouldn't. He left and headed toward Jebus (Jerusalem) with two saddled donkeys and his concubine. **11**When they got close to Jebus, it was late in the day, and the servant said, *"Let's stop at this city of the Jebusites and spend the night."*

12His master said,

> *"We won't turn aside to a city that doesn't belong to Israel. We'll go on toward Gibeah.* **13***Let's get close to a place there and spend the night at Gibeah or Ramah."*

14So they went on past *Jebus*. The sun went down on them near Gibeah, in Benjamin. **15**They stopped there to go in and spend the night. He sat down in the open square of the town because nobody had taken them home.

Jud 19:10-15

16At evening an old man came in from working in the field. He was from the hill country of Ephraim and living in Gibeah. The men there were Benjamites. **17**He saw the traveler in the open square and said, *"Where are you from, and where are you going?"*

> **18**He said, *"We're going from Bethlehem to a distant part of Ephraim, where I come from. I went to Bethlehem, and I'm going home. Nobody is taking me to his house.* **19***We have straw and hay for our donkeys, with bread and wine for me, my maidservant, and the young man with us. We have everything we need."*

20The old man said, *"Don't worry. I'll take care of everything you need. Just don't spend the night in the square."*

21He took him into his house and gave the donkeys hay. They washed their feet and ate.

Jud 19:16-21

22As they were relaxing, some riffraff from the town surrounded the house, beating on the door and saying to the old man that owned the house, *"Bring the man out that came to your house so we can rape him."* **23**The man went out and said,

> *"No, brothers, don't do something so wicked. He has come to my house; don't do that awful thing.* **24***Here are my virgin daughter and his concubine. Let me bring them out now. Ravish them and do with them what you want, but don't do such an awful thing."*

25But the men wouldn't listen, so the man grabbed his concubine and put her out to them. They raped her and abused her all night till morning. As it started getting daylight, they let her go. **26**She came and fell down at the door of the house where her husband was.

27Her husband got up in the morning; and when he opened the doors to leave, his concubine was lying there with her hands on the threshold. **28**He said to her, *"Get up; let's go on."* But she didn't answer. He put her on the donkey and went on to his home. **29**When he got there, he took a knife and divided her limb by limb into 12 pieces and sent them all over Israel. **30**Everybody that saw it said, *"Such an awful thing has never happened since Israel came up from Egypt. Consider it, take counsel, and speak."*

Jud 19:22-30

Israel Fights the Benjamites

20:1 The people came out from Dan to Beersheba, including Gilead, and gathered in unity to the LORD at Mizpah. **2**The chiefs from all the tribes presented themselves in the assembly of God's people, 400,000 infantry that drew sword. **3**(Now the Benjamites heard that the people had gone up to Mizpah.) They said, *"How did this wickedness happen?"* **4**The Levite, husband of the murdered woman, said,

> *"My concubine and I came to Gibeah, in Benjamin, to spend the night.* **5***The men there rose against me and set on the house around me after dark. They meant to kill me. They raped my concubine, and she's dead.* **6***I cut her up in pieces and sent them all over Israel because they've committed a detestable, disgraceful act.* **7***People of Israel, all of you, give your advice and counsel here."*

8The people arose in agreement,

> *"None of us will go to his tent or house.* **9***We'll go up against Gibeah by lot.* **10***We'll take 10 men from 100 from all the tribes, 100 from 1,000, 1,000 from 10,000, to bring provisions for the people, so when they come, they can pay back Gibeah for that awful crime."*

[11]The men of Israel gathered in unity against the town. **Jud 20:1-11**

[12]The tribes of Israel sent men through the whole tribe of Benjamin, and said, *"What's this wickedness that's taken place among you? [13]Give up the base men of Gibeah, so we can put them to death and purge sin from Israel."* But the Benjamites wouldn't listen. [14]They came together out of the towns to Gibeah to fight. [15]That day they mustered 26,000 swordsmen, besides 700 elite men in Gibeah. [16]Among them were 700 elite men that were left-handed. Every one could sling a stone at a hair and not miss. [17]Israel, not including those from Benjamin, mustered 400,000 swordsmen.

[18]The people of Israel went up to Bethel and asked God, *"Which of us should go up first to fight Benjamin?"* The LORD said, *"Judah."* [19]The people got up in the morning and camped against Gibeah. [20]They went out to fight Benjamin and drew up the battle line against them at Gibeah. [21]The Benjamites came out of Gibeah and felled 22,000 Israelites that day. [22]But the people took courage and formed the battle line again in the same place. [23]They went up and cried to the LORD till evening and asked him, *"Should we go again against our relatives the Benjamites?"*

"Yes." **Jud 20:12-23**

[24]So they attacked the Benjamites the second day. [25]Benjamin went against them out of Gibeah the second day and felled 18,000 swordsmen. [26]Then the entire army of Israel went up to Bethel and cried. They sat in front of the LORD and fasted that day till evening and offered burnt offerings and peace offerings to the LORD. [27](The Ark was there at that time, [28]and Phinehas son of Eleazar son of Aaron performed service in front of it.) They asked him, *"Should we go up again against our fellow Jews?"*

"Yes, I'll deliver them to you tomorrow."

[29]Israel set men in ambush around Gibeah. [30]On the third day, they went up against the Benjamites and set themselves in formation against Gibeah like before. [31]The Benjamites came out against them and drew away from the town. As at other times, they began to strike down and kill some people in the highways—one that goes up to Bethel, the other to Gibeah—and in the countryside, about 30 men of Israel. [32]The Benjamites said, *"They're routed like the first time."* But the men of Israel said, *"Let's retreat and draw them away from the town onto the highways."* [33]They rose up out of their place and set themselves in formation at Baal-tamar, and the men lying in ambush rushed out of their place west of Geba. [34]10,000 elite men out of all Israel attacked Gibeah. The battle was hard, but the Benjamites didn't know that disaster was coming. [35]The LORD defeated Benjamin in front of Israel. Israel destroyed 25,100 Benjamite swordsmen that day. [36]Then the Benjamites realized they were defeated. **Jud 20:24-36a**

The men of Israel gave ground, because they relied on the ones in ambush to attack the town. [37]The men in ambush hurried out and struck the whole town with the sword. [38]The signal

by the men in ambush was that when they made a big cloud of smoke rise out of the town, [39]the men of Israel should turn around in battle. Benjamin said, *"We've struck them down like in the first battle."* [40]But when the signal began to rise, the Benjamites looked back. The whole town was going up in smoke. [41]Then Israel turned around and Benjamin panicked when they saw that disaster was on them. [42]So they turned their backs on Israel toward open country, but the battle overtook them. Those who came out of the towns [43]cut them down and pursued them down from Nohah all the way across from Gibeah to the east. [44]18,000 Benjamites fell. [45]They turned and fled toward the open country to the Rock of Rimmon. On the roads they cut down 5,000 *more* and pursued them hard to Gidom and killed another 2,000. [46]25,000 Benjamites fell that day, trained soldiers. [47]But 600 fled toward open country to the Rock of Rimmon and stayed there four months. [48]The men of Israel turned back and struck them with the sword, people and animals and everybody they found. They set on fire the towns they found. **Jud 20:36b-48**

Wives for Benjamites

21:[1]The men of Israel had sworn at Mizpah that none of them would give his daughter in marriage to Benjamin. [2]The people came to Bethel and sat till evening in front of God and cried bitterly. [3]*"LORD God of Israel, why has this happened that a tribe should be missing from Israel?"* [4]The people got up early the next day, built an altar, and offered burnt offerings and peace offerings. [5]They said, *"Which tribe didn't come up to the assembly to the LORD?"* They'd taken an oath at Mizpah to put to death anyone that didn't come up to the LORD. [6]They felt sorry for Benjamin, their fellow Jews, *"A tribe has been eliminated from Israel today. [7]What are we going to do for wives for the ones that are left? We've sworn by the LORD not to give them our daughters for wives."* **Jud 21:1-7**

[8]They said, *"What tribe didn't come up?"* [9]When the people mustered, not one person from Jabesh-gilead was there. [10]The community sent 12,000 of their bravest men, *"Go strike the people in Jabesh-gilead with the sword, including women and children. [11]Destroy every male and every woman that has been with a man."* [12]They found 400 young virgins in Jabesh-gilead and brought them to the camp at Shiloh in Canaan.

[13]Then the whole community sent word to Benjamin at the Rock of Rimmon to announce a truce. [14]Benjamin came back, and they gave them the women they'd saved from Jabesh-gilead, but they weren't enough. [15]The people had mercy on Benjamin because the LORD had created a division in the tribes. **Jud 21:8-15**

[16]The elders of the community said,

> *"What are we going to do for the rest of them? The women from Benjamin had been destroyed. [17]There has to be an inheritance for the survivors so a tribe doesn't disappear. [18]But we can't give them our daughters for wives."*

The people had sworn, *"Anybody that gives a wife to Benjamin is under a course."*

19They said, *"There's the annual festival of the LORD at Shiloh, north of Bethel, east of the road from Bethel to Shechem and south of Lebonah."*

20They told the Benjamites,

"Lie in wait in the vineyards **21***and watch. If the young women of Shiloh come out to dance in the dances, each man come out of the vineyards, grab his wife, and go to Benjamin's land.* **22***When their fathers or brothers complain to us, we'll say, 'Grant them graciously to us because we didn't take wives for them in battle. You didn't give them wives; otherwise, you'd be guilty.'"*

23The Benjamites did that and took their wives according to their number from the dancers they carried off. They went back to their inheritance, rebuilt the towns, and lived in them. **24**Each man of Israel went to his tribe and family, to his inheritance.

25In those days there wasn't a king in Israel. Everybody did what seemed right to them.

Jud 21:16-25

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